Henry VIII

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For other uses, see Henry VIII (disambiguation).

Henry VIII (28 June 1491 – 28 January 1547)[e] was King of England from 22 April 1509 until his death in 1547. After the pope refused to annul his marriage to Catherine of Aragon, Henry passed legislation that severed England and Ireland from the Roman Catholic Church and established the monarch as Supreme Head of the Church of England, initiating the English Reformation. He subsequently married five more times; two marriages were annulled and two wives were executed.

Henry was born in Greenwich as the second son of Henry VII and Elizabeth of York. His elder brother, Arthur, Prince of Wales, was heir apparent until his death in 1502, after which Henry succeeded him. Originally intended for an ecclesiastical career, he instead received an education suited to kingship. Of his six siblings, only Margaret and Mary survived into adulthood.

Henry brought radical changes to the Constitution of England, expanding royal power and ushering in the theory of the divine right of kings in opposition to papal supremacy. He frequently used charges of treason and heresy to quell dissent, and those accused were often executed without a formal trial using bills of attainder. He achieved many of his political aims through his chief ministers, some of whom were banished or executed when they fell out of his favour. Thomas Wolsey, Thomas More, Thomas Cromwell, and Thomas Cranmer all figured prominently in his administration.

Henry was an extravagant spender, using proceeds from the dissolution of the monasteries and acts of the Reformation Parliament. He converted money that was formerly paid to Rome into royal revenue. Despite the money from these sources, he was often on the verge of financial ruin due to personal extravagance and the costs of his largely unproductive wars with France and Scotland. He founded the Royal Navy, oversaw the annexation of Wales to England with the Laws in Wales Acts 1535 and 1542, and was the first English monarch to rule as King of Ireland following the Crown of Ireland Act 1542.

Henry's contemporaries considered him an attractive, educated, and accomplished king. He has been described as "one of the most charismatic rulers to sit on the English throne" and his reign described as the "most important" in English history.[5][6] He was an author and composer. As he aged, he became severely overweight and his health suffered, and he was frequently characterised in his later life as a lustful, egotistical, paranoid, and tyrannical monarch.[7][8] He longed for a son and heir, which he finally received from his third marriage to Jane Seymour. Jane's son succeeded Henry as Edward VI. Nonetheless, his daughters by his first and second wives acceded to the throne in turn as Mary I and Elizabeth I.

Henry VIII

Portrait of Henry VIII c. 1540–1547

King of England
Lord/King of Ireland[a] (more...)

Reign	22 April 1509[b] – 28 January 1547
Coronation	24 June 1509
Predecessor	Henry VII
Successor	Edward VI
Born	28 June 1491 Palace of Placentia, Greenwich, England
Died	28 January 1547 (aged 55) Palace of Whitehall, Westminster, England
Burial	16 February 1547 St George's Chapel, Windsor Castle, Berkshire
Spouses	Catherine of Aragon (m. 1509; ann. 1533)[c] Anne Boleyn (m. 1532; ann. 1536)[d] Jane Seymour (m. 1536; died 1537) Anne of Cleves